National independent statehood for Kashmir has also often been mooted over the past sixty years, initially by the maharajah of Kashmir himself, and most recently by a number of young Azaadis in Srinagar, but that proposal has never won any official support from either India or Pakistan, without which it remains an implausible option.

The most realistic solution to the Kashmir conflict, therefore, would appear to be acceptance of the current Line of Control that now divides the former princely state of Jammu and Kashmir as the northernmost international border of India and Pakistan. Though many Pakistanis still favor reunification of the Vale of Kashmir and its integration into Pakistan, based on the tested preferences of its majority, Pakistan's tragic failure to sustain a freely elected civil polity capable of protecting its own people for long, whatever their gender or faith might be, has reduced virtually to zero the credibility of its repeated demands for self-determination for Kashmir's Muslim majority. Until Pakistan's elected leaders are strong enough to control the Al-Qaeda and Taliban militants who inhabit its entire Afghan frontier, and to end the nurturing on Pakistani soil of suicide bombers bent on killing Indians, Americans, Sri Lankans, or other innocent people the world over, their demands for a democratic resolution of Kashmir's conflict will have little credibility and win scant support.

To suggest, however, that the most feasible solution to the Kashmir conflict should be to accept the status quo of the current territorial division of the Vale of Kashmir is not to argue that India should continue its military occupation and praetorian attacks on Kashmir's Muslim majority. The people of Kashmir themselves must be permitted to choose their own leaders in free and fair elections, as do Indians in every other state in that union, and New Delhi should solemnly commit to supporting Kashmir's provincial autonomy and the human rights of its people, as it does the autonomy and rights of the people of Punjab, Maharashtra, or West Bengal. India's present United Progressive Alliance should have no difficulty endorsing so humane an agreement, since, as Prime Minister Manmohan Singh said when launching the first Kashmir train service on 11 October 2008: "We must create conditions whereby a Kashmiri living in Srinagar or Muzaffarabad should not see any problem about people-to-people contacts." He then wisely welcomed better relations with Pakistan as "essential" to India's "best" interests. Ten days later the Line of Control was opened for the first time in sixty years to civil trade between Srinagar and Muzaffarabad, though that traffic in the reverse direction proved less promising in its first months at least, some of the